

INDEPENDENT CONSULTING AGREEMENT

This Independent Consulting Agreement (this "Agreement") is made this 3rd day of February, 2025 (the "Effective Date"), between Beatrice Kowalczyk, an individual residing at 1105 Sycamore Row, Charleston, SC 29401 ("Consultant"), and Vantage Group LLC, a Delaware limited liability company with offices at 830 Third Ave, 9th Floor, New York, NY 10022 ("Client"), represented for all purposes under this Agreement by Howard Ellison, Director of Regulatory Affairs.

WHEREAS, Client wishes to engage Beatrice Kowalczyk to provide regulatory advisory services in connection with Client's expansion into additional state markets; and WHEREAS, Beatrice Kowalczyk agrees to provide such services on the terms below; NOW, THEREFORE, the parties agree as follows:

- 1. Services.** Consultant shall provide the services described in Exhibit A (the "Services"). Howard Ellison shall serve as Client's primary contact and shall have authority to approve deliverables and schedule changes. Consultant shall determine the manner and means of performing the Services.
- 2. Term.** This Agreement begins on 02/03/2025 and continues until terminated by either party on thirty (30) days' written notice, or immediately by either party on material breach that remains uncured ten (10) days after written notice of the breach.
- 3. Compensation.** Client shall pay Consultant at the rate of \$210 per hour, invoiced monthly in arrears with reasonable supporting detail. Undisputed invoices are due within thirty (30) days of receipt. Payments shall be made in US dollars by wire to Consultant's account at Indigo Coast Bank, routing number 053204413, account number 7714402611, or as Consultant otherwise directs in writing.
- 4. Expenses.** Client shall reimburse pre-approved, reasonable out-of-pocket expenses at cost. Airfare above premium economy and any single expense over \$500 require prior written approval from Howard Ellison.
- 5. Independent Contractor; Tax Matters.** Consultant is an independent contractor, not an employee, and is responsible for all self-employment and income taxes. For IRS reporting, Beatrice Kowalczyk provides taxpayer identification number 545002190 and will receive Form 1099-NEC. Consultant is not eligible for Client benefit plans.
- 6. Confidentiality.** Consultant shall hold Client's non-public information in confidence, use it only to perform the Services, and return or destroy it on request. These obligations survive termination for five (5) years, and indefinitely for trade secrets. Consultant may retain one archival copy where required by professional regulation.
- 7. Work Product.** Deliverables prepared specifically for Client under Exhibit A are assigned to Client on payment in full. Consultant retains ownership of pre-existing materials, templates, and methodologies, and grants Client a perpetual, non-exclusive license to use them as embedded in the deliverables.
- 8. Conflicts; Non-Solicitation.** Consultant represents that no current engagement conflicts with the Services. During the term and for twelve (12) months after, neither party will solicit for employment any employee of the other with whom it worked under this Agreement, except through general advertisements.
- 9. Liability.** Neither party is liable for indirect, incidental, or consequential damages. Each party's total liability under this Agreement is capped at the fees paid or payable in the twelve (12) months preceding the claim, except for breaches of Section 6 or amounts owed under Section 3.
- 10. Insurance.** Consultant shall maintain professional liability insurance of at least \$1,000,000 per claim for the duration of the engagement and shall provide a certificate of insurance on request.
- 11. Notices.** Notices must be in writing and are effective on receipt. Notices shall be sent to b.kowalczyk@kmzadvisory.com for Consultant and to howard.ellison@vantagegrp.com for Client, with copies by post to the addresses in the preamble. Operational questions may be directed to Client's New York switchboard at (212) 555-0184 or to Consultant's office line at (843) 555-0158.

12. Data Protection. To the extent Consultant processes personal data on Client's behalf, Consultant shall do so only on Client's documented instructions, apply appropriate technical and organizational safeguards, notify Client without undue delay of any personal data breach, and, on termination, delete or return such data at Client's election. Consultant shall not transfer Client personal data outside the United States without Client's prior written consent.

13. Records; Audit. Consultant shall keep complete and accurate time records supporting each invoice for two (2) years after the relevant invoice date. Not more than once per year, on fifteen (15) days' notice, Client may have an independent accountant review those records during business hours, solely to verify amounts invoiced. Overcharges confirmed by the review shall be refunded within thirty (30) days.

14. Publicity. Neither party may use the other's name or logo in client lists, press releases, or marketing materials without prior written consent, except that Consultant may describe the engagement generically (sector, scope, dates) in proposals.

15. Force Majeure. Neither party is liable for delay or failure to perform caused by events beyond its reasonable control, provided it gives prompt notice and resumes performance as soon as practicable. Client's payment obligations for Services already performed are not excused.

16. Counterparts; Electronic Signature. This Agreement may be executed in counterparts, including by electronic signature, each of which is an original and all of which together are one instrument.

17. General. This Agreement, with its Exhibits, is the entire agreement and supersedes prior discussions. It may be amended only in writing signed by both parties. It is governed by the laws of the State of South Carolina, without regard to conflicts rules; the parties consent to exclusive jurisdiction and venue in Charleston County. If any provision is unenforceable, the remainder stays in effect. Neither party may assign this Agreement without the other's written consent, except to a successor in a merger or asset sale.

EXECUTION

CONSULTANT: Beatrice Kowalczyk

Date: 02/03/2025

CLIENT (Vantage Group LLC): Howard Ellison

Date: 02/03/2025

Subscribed and sworn before me this 3rd day of February, 2025, by Beatrice Kowalczyk and Howard Ellison, both personally known to me.

Notary Public: Felicia Grant, State of South Carolina
My commission expires 09/30/2027.

EXHIBIT A · SCOPE OF SERVICES

Consultant will support Client's US market-entry program across the following workstreams:

A1. Regulatory landscape assessment: map federal and state licensing requirements applicable to Client's product lines; deliver a written assessment and license-priority matrix.

A2. Application support: prepare and review license applications in up to eight (8) states, coordinating with Client's outside counsel where filings require attorney signature.

A3. Compliance program design: draft policies, complaint-handling procedures, and a monitoring calendar suitable for a first US compliance hire to operate.

A4. Regulator liaison: attend up to six (6) meetings with state regulators as Client's designated consultant of record.

Milestone	Target date	Fee cap (hrs)
Landscape assessment delivered	March 14, 2025	60
First-wave applications filed	April 30, 2025	120
Compliance program handed over	June 16, 2025	80
Regulator meetings completed	August 29, 2025	40

Reporting cadence: Consultant will send a written status summary each Friday to Howard Ellison, join a 30-minute video check-in on alternate Tuesdays, and flag any risk to a milestone date within two (2) business days of identifying it.

Out of scope: tax structuring advice, lobbying or government relations, legal opinions, and any service that must be performed by licensed counsel. Requests outside Exhibit A require a signed change order referencing this Agreement.

EXHIBIT B · RATES AND INVOICING

Standard rate: \$210/hour. Travel time is billed at 50% of the standard rate; travel days are capped at eight (8) billable hours including work performed. Invoices are submitted monthly from invoicing@kmzadvisory.com and should reference Client purchase order VG-2025-0117. Client's accounts-payable contact is Renata Osei, ap@vantagegrp.com, (212) 555-0121.

Item	Basis	Rate
Advisory services (Exhibit A)	hourly	\$210.00
Travel time	hourly, 50%	\$105.00
Regulator meeting attendance	half-day minimum	\$840.00
Document production support	hourly	\$210.00
Mileage	per IRS standard rate	\$0.70/mi
Lodging / airfare	at cost, pre-approved	pass-through

Invoices unpaid forty-five (45) days after receipt accrue simple interest at 1.0% per month. Client may not offset disputed amounts from other invoices; disputes must be raised in writing within fifteen (15) days of invoice receipt and are escalated first to Howard Ellison and Beatrice Kowalczyk for good-faith resolution.